Remote work, social life and work-life boundaries

We are a group of students of the Human-Computer Interaction course at Politecnico di Torino (Group Us Ability). We are studying how people who work fully remotely manage their social life and the boundaries between work and personal time. There are no right or wrong answers: we are interested in your real, everyday experience. It takes about 10–15 minutes.

Informed consent

Participation is voluntary and anonymous. Your answers will be used only for this university project, analysed in aggregate and not shared with third parties. You can stop at any time by closing the page: unsent answers are not saved. If you leave your email at the end, it will be used only to contact you for a possible follow-up interview.

Do you agree to take part in this study? *

- (●) Yes, I agree
- ( ) No, I do not agree

Who this study is for

This study is only for people who work fully remotely. If that is not your case, the form will end here: thank you anyway!

Do you currently work fully remotely? *

- (●) Yes, fully remote (at most a few days in an office per year)
- ( ) Hybrid: I go to an office or on-site regularly
- ( ) No, I mostly work in an office or on-site
- ( ) I am not working at the moment

Age

How old are you? *

- ( ) Under 25
- ( ) 25–29
- ( ) 30–35
- (●) 36 or older

Your remote history

Were you already working fully remotely when you were around 35 years old? *

- (●) Yes
- ( ) No

About you

Gender

- ○ Woman
- ◉ Man
- ○ Non-binary
- ○ Prefer not to say
- ○ Altro: _____

Country (and city) where you live

Exeter, UK

What is your job / role? *

E.g. software developer, designer, customer support...

Software Developer

Who do you live with? *

- ○ Alone
- ◉ With my partner
- ○ With my partner and/or children
- ○ With flatmates
- ○ With my parents / family of origin
- ○ Altro: _____

How often do you do physical activity or sport? *

- ○ Almost never
- ○ Occasionally
- ○ 1–2 times a week
- ◉ 3 or more times a week

Your workday

Describe your last typical workday, from when you woke up to when you stopped working. *

Where were you, when did you take breaks, who did you talk to…

Morning work 9:30-14:00 with break for 2nd coffee, break for exercise, afternoon work 16:00-18:30, break for supper, evening work 20:30-23:00. About 10 minutes of phone calls. Mainly talking via Slack. On Saturday and Sunday I only work half time, typically 12:00-14:00, 17:00-18:30, 20:30-23:30

How do you mark the start and the end of your workday? Do you have any habits or rituals? *

Start with Coffee and reviewing work done while I was sleeping. End of workday is a shower and leaving work in progress in a clean state. I exercise most days from 1400-1600. I don't eat lunch except a piece of fruit. My habits include using pen and paper to write out daily and weekly tasks with a fountain pen. research and decisions are written down on paper.

In the last month, how often did you… *

	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Always
…keep working after your planned end time	◉	○	○	○	○
…check work messages outside working hours	○	○	○	◉	○
…eat lunch at your desk or skip it	○	○	○	○	◉
…feel unable to switch off from work	○	◉	○	○	○
…spend a whole day without leaving home	○	○	○	◉	○

Think about the last time work spilled over into your personal time. What happened, and how did you feel? *

I took a phone call from a customer during supper yesterday. It is an easy decision, if we don't sell our product then we don't make money, and if we don't make money then I don't have a job. No company is entitled to a profit, and no company survives long term without profit. It is clear to every employee the requirements of the job, and everyone joined voluntarily and can leave when they no longer want to do it.

Social life and connection

In a normal week, how many people do you talk to in person (not on video), excluding those you live with? *

- ○ None
- ◉ 1–2
- ○ 3–5
- ○ 6 or more

How do you interact with colleagues beyond strictly work-related tasks? (select all that apply) *

- ☑ Informal chat channels (e.g. #random on Slack)
- ☐ Virtual coffee breaks / social calls
- ☑ In-person meetups, retreats or offsites
- ☐ I meet some colleagues privately as friends
- ☐ I don't really interact beyond work
- ☐ I don't have colleagues (freelancer / solo)
- ☐ Altro: .....

How connected do you feel to your colleagues? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Not at all	○	○	○	○	◉	Very much

How satisfied are you with your social life outside work? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Not at all	○	○	○	○	◉	Very much

How has remote work changed your social life? Tell us both positive and negative aspects. *

I save time in my day and money by not travelling for work, this gives me time and money for my own enjoyment. I take 2 hours in the middle of the day for my own time and it is more efficient than travelling when many people are on the road. I can talk with colleagues over Zoom, it can be very personal and no one overhears us, I feel safer sharing my feelings. I see my colleagues spouse and children and pets. There are almost no negatives.

Tell us about the last time you felt lonely or isolated because of how you work. If it never happens, what do you think protects you from it?

Everyone spends at least £1,000 on audio and video equipment so we have very good and easy conversations with each other. We can get on video chat within 10 seconds. We can talk about anything and everything about life. I could not do that in an office. Sometimes I go to the golf club to work, or to the beach if I want to get out of the house.

Strategies and tools

What do you currently do to keep work and personal life separate? *

Bad question. I don't need or want to keep them separate, I have 1 life. I enjoy my work. It is hard, it is frustrating. But so is exercise.

Which of these do you use for focus, time, wellbeing or socialising? (select all that apply)

- [ ] Calendar blocking
- [ ] Focus / Pomodoro timers
- [ ] Do-not-disturb or notification schedules
- [ ] Meditation / wellbeing apps
- [x] Fitness trackers or sport apps
- [ ] Apps to meet people (e.g. Meetup)
- [x] A separate device or account for work
- [ ] None of these
- [x] Altro: Good headphones.

Have you ever tried something (a habit, a tool, a group, a routine) to improve your boundaries or social life and then given up? What was it and why did you stop?

Bad question. This suggests boundaries are desirable. I am happy going to bed thinking about solving work problems. I am happy thinking about work in the shower. Some people may want to put different aspects of their life into compartments, but assuming this is universally desired is wrong. It is also a popular thought and is people's default position, which usually means it is not well contemplated and people fail to consider the question if compartmentalised life is desirable.

If you could change one thing about how remote work affects your wellbeing, what would it be and why? *

I like driving my car, I have less reasons to do it.

Where you work

Where do you work most often? *

- (●) At home, in a room used only for work
- ( ) At home, in a shared space (bedroom, kitchen, living room)
- ( ) In a coworking space
- ( ) In cafés, libraries or other public places
- ( ) It changes often / while travelling

Working outside home

A few questions about working from coworking spaces or public places.

How many days a week do you work outside home? *

- ( ) 1 day
- ( ) 2–3 days
- ( ) 4–5 days
- ( ) Every day, including weekends

What made you start working there instead of at home? *

Do you interact with the other people who work there? Describe the last meaningful interaction you had (or why it does not happen). *

How do your workday start and end differ on days you work there compared to days at home?

What does not work for you in these spaces (cost, noise, privacy, people, distance…)?

Your working hours

Which of these best describes your working hours? *

- ○ Standard hours, same time zone as my team
- ○ I work with people 1–3 hours apart
- ◉ I work with people more than 3 hours apart
- ○ Shifted or irregular hours (very early, late evening, night, weekends)

Time zones and shifted hours

In which hours (your local time) do you usually work? *

E.g. 14:00–22:00

9:30-23:00

How do you organise sleep, meals and free time around these hours? *

I eat breakfast before work. I take off 2 hours in the middle of the day.

Tell us about the last time your schedule made you miss or give up something social (a dinner, an event, sport…). What happened? *

It rarely happens. My company allows unlimited time off. A year ago there was an emergency and I didn't exercise for 2 weeks because of work requirements.

When your colleagues are online and you are not (or the other way round), how do you handle messages and the feeling of having to be available?

There is no feeling of having to be available. Our company is structured to function asynchronously. All important meetings are recorded and can be watched later. All decisions happen in google docs over multiple days. We generally have a principle that if work relies on synchronous communication we have a problem. We call this the "bus factor" - the company continues to function even if half the company is hit by a bus and dies.

Do the people around you (partner, friends, flatmates, family) adapt to your schedule? How?

I chose my schedule to fit around my wife, my company does not choose my schedule.

Your remote experience

How long have you been working fully remotely? *

- ○ Less than 1 year
- ○ 1–3 years
- ○ 3–5 years
- ◉ More than 5 years

Long-term remote work

How have your habits around work and free time changed since your first months fully remote? *

I have a dedicated office, my wife understands that when I'm at work I am not available for chores, I reach out to people proactively rather than relying on communication over lunch in the office.

Was there a period when remote work weighed on you more than usual? What was going on, and what helped?

I was the only remote worker at a previous job, and the company was not setup for asynchronous communication, so I had a hard time being effective at my job.

What did you have to learn the hard way that you would tell someone starting full remote today?

It will make bad colleagues worse at their job. Remote is best when you have high performing people that don't need to be monitored.

Have you ever considered going back to the office or to a hybrid job? Why, and what did you decide?

Yes, but only in walking distance, and only if I had a private office. I no longer function well in a loud environment.

Almost done

To show you the right final questions, which age group are you in? *

- ○ Under 35
- ◉ 36 or older

Your perspective

A few questions for those over 35: your experience helps us compare different stages of life.

Compared to when you were under 35, how has the way you balance work, free time and social life changed? *

I work fewer hours now because I do less learning on the job. I can use my experience to work faster than my younger colleagues.

What has changed in your priorities in recent years (career, family, health, friendships), and how does remote work fit with them? *

Health is now much more important, and I love being at the gym when it is quiet. At 18:00 the gym is far too busy and noisy. I have much more knowledge about the limits of my abilities and am more comfortable with my position - I know I don't have the right mental ability or skills or desire for certain roles that I wanted when I was younger.

In your current stage of life, what makes it easier or harder to meet new people or keep in touch with friends?

Life at 25 and 40 is not very different, I can still do most things I did at 25, and I have money to do more things at 40.

Do your friends of the same age live with different rhythms (office jobs, children, shifts)? How does this affect when and how you see them?

The actual big change is difference in savings and salary. Friends suddenly have a 5x difference in income, some saved and have a house, others continue to struggle because they were frivolous with their spending. Friends with a nice watch and car at 25 are generally poorer. People who saved have houses and host dinner parties. Some of us can go on a group holiday, others can't.

Is there something you do today to protect your wellbeing that you wish you had started earlier? Why?

Art and surrounding myself with beauty. Choosing my own preferences and my own hobbies. There are over 1000 hobbies, I love having the choice and finding beauty in the ones I choose, especially when they are affordable. If you don't like a piece of art, then it isn't for you and your opinion doesn't matter, move on.

How do you think your experience of remote work differs from that of colleagues in their twenties?

A dedicated office is a big upgrade. Living with someone else is good for my happiness, I would be much less happy living alone.

Before going fully remote, how many years had you worked in an office or on-site? *

- ○ Never / less than 2 years
- ◉ 2–10 years
- ○ 10–20 years
- ○ More than 20 years

What led you to work fully remotely at this stage of your life and career? *

I have worked remotely 3 different times. 1 - local company office shut down, 2 - lack of interesting jobs in my city, 3 - much higher salary.

Have you noticed younger colleagues struggling with boundaries or isolation in ways you do not? Tell us about a concrete situation. *

No, the opposite. Younger colleagues tend to move to different cities or countries much more often because they are not tied down to their job and are not yet married. They have the freedom to live near the mountains, or buy a big house in a cheap area.

Do you ever support or advise younger remote colleagues (formally or informally)? How does it happen at a distance?

Zoom. My camera costs over £1500 . We have 1-1 meetings all the time, and we reserve time after group meetings to just hang out.

Which habits or rules did you bring from office life that still help you today?

Interrupting people is rude.

How has remote work affected your physical health (movement, posture, sleep, energy), and what do you do about it?

I chose my own desk, chair, monitor, keyboard and they are all much better than you get in a typical office. I am much more efficient in exercise and can use the gym when it is not busy.

How comfortable are you with the digital tools of remote work (chat, video calls, async tools)? Is there one that makes switching off harder?

This is not an issue, it is not a technical issue, this is a culture problem.

How do you think your experience of remote work differs from that of younger colleagues? *

No.

If you worked in an office in the past: what do you miss, and what don't you miss at all?

I miss the free food and the long lunch breaks at a restaurant. I do not miss the noise and the commute.

Over the years, how did you build your circle of friends, and how much of it comes from work?

I've never used work as a primary source of friends. I join clubs.

How do family or other responsibilities shape the boundaries between your work and personal time?

I love being able to take 5 minutes out of the day to accept a delivery, pet my cat, move the laundry to the dryer or other small chores when I need a quick break.

Last questions

Is there anything else about remote work, social life or boundaries you would like to tell us?

Remote vs. In-office work is not very different today, technology has solved almost all communication difficulties. It is actually easier to communicate today versus 10 years ago in an office when I might need to walk 5-10 minutes to someone else's desk, or need to book a meeting room far away. If you want boundaries that is easy, close your computer when you are done working, shut your office door, and it is just like leaving an office building. The upsides are huge - imagine being able to find the best colleagues out of a population of 200-500 million people versus what you can get in a city of 500,000. And that is what really makes work enjoyable - working with other high performing people.

On the other hand, a large percentage of the population lacks discipline to work without being monitored, they need the constraints of an office to keep them productive. Managing people in the bottom 10% is a vastly different experience, and it is uncomfortable to talk about this publicly because it implies the bottom 10% deserve less, or it's their own fault. But the reality is that drug and alcohol use at work is a big issue, showing up to work at all is an issue, fighting, theft, intentional destruction of property, and low reading skills are all issues managers face daily. Employing these people is very hard and requires different techniques - I can imagine remote work causing a large decrease in their productivity without specialist monitoring tools. I speak from experience managing people who spoke little English, had drug problems, been to prison, or generally lacked impulse control.

Would you be available for a short follow-up interview (30–45 min, in person or video call)? *

- (●) Yes
- ( ) No

Contact Info

If yes, leave your email or any other social to be contacted *

williams.ross@gmail.com

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